

## **PHIL 2050: Ethics and Values**

Spring Semester 2026

### **Course Description**

The implementation of ethics and values scaffold much of our world. In this course, students will learn how to identify and analyze ethical dilemmas by examining real-life case studies. They will learn about different ethical frameworks in which to analyze approaches to these dilemmas. We will cover ethical theories such as consequentialism, deontology, and virtue ethics, and areas of application in bioethics, law, animal ethics, and personal identity.

### **Course Outcomes and Objectives**

Over the course of the semester, students will:

- Consider recent ethical issues of concern to medical practitioners and researchers
- Become familiar with major theories of moral philosophy, and the standard principles of bioethics
- Articulate and defend an interpretation of an ethical dilemma using one of the primary moral theories
- Use concepts from ethics & philosophy to analyze the dilemma
- Engage in constructive discussion with others
- Apply philosophical thinking to ethical dilemmas in your personal and professional life
- Strengthen critical thinking and reading comprehension skills
- Extract subtle points from complicated readings, and use these in the construction of their own arguments.

### **Agenda**

For the first few weeks, we will focus on the ethical foundations setting the stage for the ethical dilemmas we will discuss. Then, for the remainder of the semester, we will discuss the ethical dilemmas themselves. There will be at least one reading each week to help you better apply the concepts we discuss. The topics covered in this course will be visible on the Canvas homepage as separate modules corresponding to weeks of the course. The reading material for every week will be accessible throughout the semester. All materials will be available under their respective modules.

## Grading Rubric:

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |     |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| <b>Overall Grade:</b> Earning 100% in the three primary categories (In-Class Participation, Online Discussion, & Final Exam) will earn you a 'B' for the class. To earn a 'B+', demonstrate mastery of the three primary categories and one advanced assignment. To earn an 'A', demonstrate mastery of the three primary categories and two advanced assignments.<br><b>NOTE:</b> You must pass all three primary components to pass this course, and pass the advanced assignments to improve your grade. Failing a primary component may lead to a failing grade. |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |     |
| <b>In-Class Participation (20%)</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | Actively participate in at least 13 classes.                                                                                                                                                                                     |     |
| <b>Online Discussion (40%)</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | Your online discussion grade is based on two components:                                                                                                                                                                         |     |
|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | % of posts turned in on time                                                                                                                                                                                                     | 33% |
|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | Successfully posting each response type.                                                                                                                                                                                         | 66% |
| <b>Final Exam (40%)</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | Your final exam grade is based on what level you reach                                                                                                                                                                           |     |
|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | Level 1: Correctly identifying and describing each major ethical theory we cover. Stopping here earns you a 'C' on your final exam.                                                                                              |     |
|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | Level 2: Identifying practical obligations of each of the covered theories. Stopping here earns you a 'B' on your final exam.                                                                                                    |     |
|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | Level 3: Explain how a theory we covered guides decision making for a case/topic we covered in class, and whether it is an appropriate application of that theory. Stopping here earns you a 'A' on your final exam.             |     |
| <b>Advanced Assignments</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | Up to two Advanced Assignments may be used to improve your grade. The first will raise your overall grade by 1/3 of a letter grade, the second by an additional 2/3. See the course Canvas page for advanced assignment options. |     |

## Course Requirement Details:

### A. IN-CLASS PARTICIPATION:

This is a college-level ethics course. While many courses can be designed to provide alternatives to talking in class, this is not one of those courses. Students will be expected to contribute to in-class discussions. The discussions we have in class will: 1) prompt students to apply the concepts discussed in the previous classes, and 2) encourage them to remember what their fellow classmates said. **Full points on this criteria will be awarded to those who talk, in an engaged way, in at least 13 classes (ignoring workshop days).** Points will be reduced based on the number of classes with missed engagement out of the 13 required.

### B. KEYWORD DISCUSSIONS:

Keyword discussions are an online exercise designed to develop your argumentative and analytical skills. Much of your engagement in the course will be here. There are two parts: (1)

initiating the conversation by selecting “keywords” from the reading; (2) discussing these keywords online.

There are eight different possible roles one can uptake during a discussion (you must choose one for *every* post):

- **Initiator.** Your job is to initiate a discussion. Propose 1-2 keywords (a word or short phrase) that capture focused, important features of the assigned text, along with concise (~100 words max) explanations of those keywords. Rule #1: Don’t be boring! Everyone’s done the reading so you don’t need to tell us the main thesis. Instead, highlight a narrow, focused aspect of the reading that you found interesting or memorable.
- **Excavator.** Your job is to identify unstated premises or assumptions in either the assigned reading, keyword proposals, or other parts of the discussion. How does making those explicit enrich the discussion?
- **Prospector.** Your job is to identify muted or understated consequences, entailments, or obligations of either the assigned reading, keyword proposals, or other parts of the discussion. How does identifying these consequences enrich the discussion?
- **Contrarian.** Your job is to test the arguments, assertions, and premises of the keyword proposals, assigned reading, or other parts of the discussion. Consider whether you might defend an opposing thesis, or another position not yet considered. The spirit of this should be constructive, seeking to advance the discussion.
- **Devil’s Advocate.** Your job is to advocate for a position with which you disagree, in order to understand that position better. Help keep us out of echo chambers and epistemic bubbles.
- **‘Say More’.** Ask someone to expand on one of their points. Identify a post you’d like to learn more about, letting people know why you found this so insightful and are so curious to hear more.
- **Dichotomy Skeptic.** Identify a binary stance or dichotomous framing that could be ‘troubled’. How does adding this complexity or nuance elevate the discussion, prompt a better analysis of the topic, or help uncover a previously unnoticed stance.
- **Eagle Eye.** Your job is to step back and help people keep an eye on the big picture, preventing us from getting lost in the weeds. Help connect your classmates' posts, relating them back to larger issues or themes in the class or to the assigned reading. Important: Be respectful, constructive, and aim to advance the discussion.

*Tips:*

— *Don’t merely report what we (all) read; tell us what you think.*

— *If you post a question—especially a rhetorical question—try to also answer it.*  
— *If you want to post more than once and adopt a different role, you may. 1-2 paragraphs is fine for these posts. Don't overthink this (I've done that for you). The goal is to facilitate an interesting discussion. If you've got something interesting to say, just say it!*

Over the semester, you must successfully perform each role at least once. Initiator posts are due the *Friday prior to the week the reading has been assigned*. The first round of responses are due by *Monday morning—at 10am—during the week the reading has been assigned*. Any post submitted after that point will not count. By the end of the semester, you will need to have posted at least one *Initiator, Excavator, Prospector, Contrarian, Devil's Advocate, Say More, Dichotomy Skeptic*, and *Eagle Eye* post.

### **C. FINAL EXAM:**

Your final exam is available to begin on the first day of class and is due at the conclusion of the designated final exam period. There are three 'levels.' As you advance through them, you will earn a higher grade on your final exam. Level 1 is correctly identifying the ethical theories we cover in class, with very short descriptions. Completing this earns you a 'C.' Level 2 is identifying practical obligations entailed by each of the theories we cover. Completing this level earns you a 'B' on your final exam. To earn an 'A' on the final exam you must complete Level 3. This is done either by connecting the moral theories we covered to a case/topic we go over in class. For more details on the requirements for completing each level please see the course Canvas page.

### **D. ADVANCED ASSIGNMENTS:**

Successfully completing the **In-Class Participation, Keyword Discussion, and Final Exam** assignments will earn you a 'B' in the class. To earn a higher grade you must complete **Advanced Assignments**. There are many to choose from, e.g., *Create a Course Playlist; Diversify the Course; Write an AJOB-Style Commentary*, among other options. You may complete up to two. The first advanced assignment will increase your overall grade by 1/3. For example—from a 'B' to a 'B+'. The second advanced assignment will increase your overall grade by an additional 2/3. For example—from a 'B+' to an 'A'.

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## **UNIVERSITY POLICIES**

### **ACCESSIBILITY**

The Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) and Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act of 1973, as amended, prohibit Utah Valley University from engaging in discrimination on the basis of

disability in any program or activity. Discrimination is also prohibited in all aspects of employment against persons with disabilities who, with reasonable accommodation, can perform the essential functions of a job. A student who believes s/he has been denied program access or otherwise discriminated against because of a disability is encouraged to initiate a grievance by contacting the Accessibility Services Director, Sherry Page at 801-863-8747. Employees can contact the ADA Coordinator, Irene Whittier at 801-863-8389. Upon request, this information is available in alternative formats, such as mp3, Braille, or large print. To request this format, email [asd@uvu.edu](mailto:asd@uvu.edu).

## **RELIGIOUS ACCOMMODATIONS**

UVU values and acknowledges a wide range of faiths and religions as part of our student body, and as such provides accommodations for students. Religious belief includes the student's faith or conscience as well as the student's participation in an organized activity conducted under the auspices of the student's religious tradition or religious organization. The accommodations include reasonable student absences from scheduled examinations or academic requirements if they create an undue hardship for sincerely held religious beliefs. For this to occur, the student must provide a written notice to the instructor of the course for which the student seeks said accommodation prior to the event. The UVU campus has a place for meditation, prayer, reflection, or other forms of individual religious expression as is described at <https://www.uvu.edu/ethics/reflectioncenter/>

## **ADDITIONAL CAMPUS RESOURCES**

**Academic Tutoring—Humanities and Social Sciences Lab:** Offers academic assistance in all areas of study, including research and writing. Located in Room LA-015; contact by email ([tutoring@uvu.edu](mailto:tutoring@uvu.edu)) or phone (801-863-5376), and find on the web at <http://www.uvu.edu/academictutoring/>. Services are free to all UVU students, and are available in both face-to-face and online tutoring sessions on a first-come/first-served basis. While tutors will not complete or correct homework for you or help you on take-home tests or quizzes, they will help you understand and reinforce concepts that you are learning in your classes.

**Writing Center:** Helps students in all stages of writing papers: brainstorming, outlining, drafting, editing, content and researching. <https://www.uvu.edu/writingcenter/> **Food Pantry:** If you have trouble affording or procuring food for any reason, know that UVU has a food pantry available: <https://www.uvu.edu/socialimpact/programs/food-pantry.html>

**Student Health Services:** Offers an array of health services to students, including wellness education and mental health services (behavioral medicine). Located in Room SC-221. Contact by phone (801-863-8876) and find on the web at <http://www.uvu.edu/studenthealth/>.

**UVU Library:** Provides a number of tutorials on how to conduct research and to properly cite sources in student work. Offers some materials on campus and an efficient Interlibrary Loan program for electronic articles, chapters and eBooks. Visit: <https://www.uvu.edu/library/>

## **ACADEMIC DISHONESTY**

Students are expected to maintain high standards of academic honesty and integrity, as outlined in the UVU Students Rights and Responsibilities Code, Section VII-D, “Academic Responsibilities”: “Each student is expected to maintain academic ethics and honesty in all its forms, including but not limited to, cheating and plagiarism as defined hereafter:

1. Cheating is the act of using or attempting to use or providing others with unauthorized information, materials or study aids in academic work. Cheating includes, but is not limited to, passing examination answers to or taking examinations for someone else, or preparing or copying other’s academic work.
2. Plagiarism is the act of appropriating any other person’s or group’s ideas or work (written, computerized, artistic, etc.) or portions thereof and passing them off as the product of one’s own work in any academic exercise or study.”
3. ChatGPT and Other Online AI Learning Support Platforms. Artificial intelligence (AI) language models, such as ChatGPT, and online assignment help tools, such as Chegg®, are examples of online learning support platforms: they cannot be used for course assignments except as explicitly authorized by the instructor. The following actions are prohibited in this course:
  - a. Submitting all or any part of an assignment statement to an online learning support platform;
  - b. Incorporating any part of an AI generated response in an assignment;
  - c. Using AI to brainstorm, formulate arguments, or template ideas for assignments; • Using AI to summarize or contextualize source materials;
  - d. Submitting your own work for this class to an online learning support platform for iteration or improvement.
  - e. Unattributed use of online learning support platforms and unauthorized sharing of instructional property are forms of scholastic dishonesty and will be treated as such. Please cite any and every source you use in completing an assignment (including all articles, books, websites, etc.). The professor will determine the punishment of any instance of cheating or plagiarism and depending upon the severity of the offense can range from failing the assignment to failing the entire course. Please see me right away if you ever have questions or uncertainties regarding plagiarism.

## **TITLE IX**

Title IX makes it clear that violence and harassment based on sex and gender (which includes sexual orientation and gender identity/expression) is a civil rights offense subject to the same

kinds of accountability and the same kinds of support applied to offenses against other protected categories such as race, national origin, color, religion, age, status as a person with a disability, veteran's status or genetic information. If you or someone you know has experienced or experiences harassment or sexual assault including, dating and domestic violence, stalking or sexual exploitation, you are encouraged to report it to the Title IX Coordinator in the Office for 10 of 11 Equal Opportunity and Affirmative Action, BA-203, (801) 863-7999. Please be aware that all faculty members and university employees are considered "Responsible Employees" and are required to report incidents of sexual misconduct and relationship violence and thus cannot guarantee confidentiality. Please know that you can seek confidential resources at UVU Student Health Services, SC-221, (801) 863-8876. Please visit [https:// www.uvu.edu/equalopportunity/](https://www.uvu.edu/equalopportunity/) for more information.

## **INCLUSIVITY**

I love a diverse classroom. You are welcome in my classroom and I want to hear your perspective. Everyone, no matter our personal backgrounds, can philosophize. We might be different, but we share a lot in common. Philosophy is hard, but we are going to try to do it together. You can argue against ideas and opinions—you should! But unjustified personal attacks on other people because of their identities will not be tolerated.

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## **Preliminary Course Schedule**

*\*Subject to change. All changes will be posted to Canvas.\**

### *Week 1: January 5-9*

1. Jan 5th
  - a. Syllabus
2. Jan 7th
  - a. Chapters 1-2 of Mill's *Utilitarianism*
  - b. Gustafsson, J. E. (2022). Bentham's mugging. *Utilitas*, 34(4):386–39. (It's a fun, quick read.)

### *Week 2: January 12-16*

1. Jan 12th
  - a. *The Good Will and the Categorical Imperative* Immanuel Kant
2. Jan 14th
  - a. Section of *Nicomachean Ethics* Aristotle

### *Week 3: January 19-23 (Monday Holiday)*

1. Jan 19th
  - a. No class (Holiday)
2. Jan 21
  - a. Ethics of Care — Nel Noddings

*Week 4: January 26-30*

1. Jan 26th
  - a. *Animalism and the Lives of Human Animals* Paul Snowdon
  - b. Locke, J., (1694) “Of Identity and Diversity,” *Essay Concerning Human Understanding*.
2. Jan 28th
  - a. Schechtman Narrative Identity

*Week 5: February 2-6*

1. Feb 2nd
  - a. Haidt, J., Koller, S., and Dias, M. (1993). “Affect, Culture, and Morality, or Is It Wrong to Eat Your Dog?” *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, Vol 65(4):613 - 628
  - b. Nagel, T., (1974) “What is it like to be a bat?” *Philosophical Review*
2. Feb 4th
  - a. *All Animals are Equal* Peter Singer
  - b. Shanks et al 2009

*Week 6: February 9-13*

1. Feb 9th
  - a. Card, R. F. (2007). Conscientious objection and emergency contraception. *The American Journal of Bioethics*, 7(6):8–14.
2. Feb 11th
  - a. Workshop day

*Week 7: February 17-20 (Monday Holiday)*

1. Feb 17th
  - a. King, M. L. (1963). Letter from Birmingham jail. *The Atlantic Monthly*, 212(2):78–88.
  - b. Wynia, M. K. (2022). Professional civil disobedience — medical-society responsibilities after Dobbs. *New England Journal of Medicine*, 387(11):959–961.
2. Feb 19th



- a. Having a Life vs Being Alive — Kushner

*Week 8: February 23-27*

1. Feb 23rd

- a. This 'point-counterpoint' exchange in: <https://journal.chestnet.org/>. (The papers are short! Read all four!)
  - i. DeCamp, M., Snyder Sulmasy, L., and Fins, J. J. (2022). POINT: Does Normothermic Regional Perfusion Violate the Ethical Principles Underlying Organ Procurement? Yes. *CHEST*, 162(2):288–290. doi: 10.1016/j.chest.2022.03.012.
  - ii. James, L., Parent, B., Moazami, N., and Smith, D. E. (2022). COUNTERPOINT: Does Normothermic Regional Perfusion Violate the Ethical Principles Underlying Organ Procurement? No.. *CHEST*, 162(2):290–292. doi: 10.1016/j.chest.2022.03.011.
  - iii. DeCamp, M., Fins, J. J., and Snyder Sulmasy, L. (2022). Rebuttal From Dr DeCamp et al. *CHEST*, 162(2):292–293. doi: 10.1016/j.chest.2022.03.014
  - iv. James, L., Parent, B., Moazami, N., and Smith, D. E. (2022). Rebuttal From Dr James et al. *CHEST*, 162(2):293–294. doi: 10.1016/j.chest.2022.03.013.

2. Feb 25th

- a. Discussion Section

*Week 9: March 2-6*

1. March 2nd

- a. Quill, T. E. (1991). Death and dignity. *New England Journal of Medicine*, 324(10):691–694. (A classic and very moving article!)
- b. Quill, T. E., Dresser, R., and Brock, D. W. (1997). The rule of double effect -- a critique of its role in end-of-life decision making. *New England Journal of Medicine*, 337(24):1768–1771.
- c. Boudreau, J. D., Somerville, M. A., and Biller-Andorno, N. (2013). Physician-Assisted-Suicide. *New England Journal of Medicine*, 368(15):1450–1452.

2. March 4th

- a. Discussion Section

**Week 10: Spring Break—March 9 - 14**

*Week 11: March 16-20*

1. March 16th

- a. Liao, S.-y. and Carbonell, V. (2023). Materialized oppression in medical tools and technologies. *The American Journal of Bioethics*, 23(4):9–23. PMID: 35262465.
2. March 18th
  - a. Tekin, S. (2021). Is Big Data the New Stethoscope? Perils of Digital Phenotyping to Address Mental Illness. *Philosophy & Technology*, 34(3):447–461.

*Week 12: March 23-27*

1. March 23rd
  - a. Knox, B., Christoffersen, P., Leggitt, K., Woodruff, Z., and Haber, M. H. (2023). Justice, vulnerable populations, and the use of conversational AI in psychotherapy. *The American Journal of Bioethics*, 23(5):48–50. doi: 10.1080/15265161.2023.2191040.
2. March 25th
  - a. Discussion section

*Week 13: March 30 - April 3*

1. March 30th
  - a. Gillon, R. (2015). Defending the four principles approach as a good basis for good medical practice and therefore for good medical ethics. *Journal of Medical Ethics*, 41(1):111–116.
  - b. Huxtable, R. (2013). For and against the four principles of biomedical ethics. *Clinical Ethics*, 8(2-3):39–43
2. April 1st
  - a. Brandt 1978

*Week 14: April 6-10*

1. April 6th
  - a. *Washington 2018*, Contextualism as a Solution to Paternalism in Psychiatric Practice
2. April 8th
  - a. *Leshner 1997*, Addiction is a Brain Disease, and It Matters
  - b. *Pickard 2021*, Is addiction a brain disease? A plea for agnosticism and heterogeneity

*Week 15: April 13-17*

1. April 13th
  - a. Hull, D. (1986). “On Human Nature,” *PSA: Proceedings of the Biennial Meeting of the Philosophy of Science Association*, Vol. 2: 3 -13.
  - b. Admunson, R. (2000). “Against Normal Function,” *Stud. Hist. Phil. Biol. & Biomed. Sci.*, Vol 31(1): 33-53.
2. April 15th

- a. Prinz, J. (forthcoming). "Is Morality Innate?" *Moral Psychology*, Oxford University Press. ^Read at least the first 15 pages^

*Week 16 (Final Week): April 20 - 22*

1. TBD: Will depend on what the class is most interested in.

**Grades Due: Monday, May 4th**